

new float-in closet to help store supplies, equipment and potentially experiments aboard the orbiting laboratory, helping the station continue its mission.

And of course, this is still a work in progress. NASA has retired of its space shuttle fleet so its involvement in the ISS is expected to be lesser over the coming years, but the other agencies are expected to continue working on it for some time.

Including the huge solar arrays, the International Space Station is a little smaller than a cricket stadium. Inside its pressurized modules, where residents live, work and sometimes play, it is as large as a five-bedroom home, with two bathrooms, a personal gymnasium and the ultimate 360-degree bay window on the world. Its total habitable volume is more than 12,000 cubic feet, and will only expand when Russia launches its next module – Nauka – in 2012.

Over 200 individuals representing 16 countries have visited the complex. Around 20,000 meals have been eaten aboard the station since the first crew took up residence in 2000. Through the course of its lifetime, astronauts have conducted over 150 spacewalks in support of space station assembly, totalling more than 1,015 hours.

With more than 600 experiments under its belt, the orbiting laboratory has provided continuous access that allows researchers and engineers the opportunity to constantly fine-tune their investigations in the unique, nearly zero-gravity environment. As a research outpost, the station is a test bed for future technologies and a research facility for new, advanced industrial materials, communications technology, medical research and more.

The International Space Station is an example of cooperation by humans and robots that is expected to become a mainstay of space exploration throughout our solar system.

But of course, it isn't going to be the only space station in the future either. China has already launched its own and other countries with space programmes, such as India, are expressing a keen interest on doing the same. 